

saying: "I'm just here looking after the program. I'm not interesting."

The Darling Harbour development, including museums, exhibition and convention centres, a hotel and casino is designed to be the jewel in the Wran Government's crown. The NSW Government desperately wants the project to be almost or completely finished by 1988, election year. This could be hampered by the continuing unrest surrounding the Builders' Labourers Federation.

Hank Laan was appointed to the authority largely because of a record of

good industrial relations and finishing projects on or ahead of schedule.

Good Weekend spoke to Hank Laan at home. He said he thought the development had been progressing satisfactorily. He said he was trying to cure problems with his neck which were caused by a car accident in 1982 and hoped to be back at the authority next year. Hank Laan was critical of "stirrers" who are suggesting he is being pushed out of the authority.

"There were even anonymous letters sent to a number of newspapers, saying there was a breakdown between myself

and the chairman. I saw it as quite a laugh. It's a high-profile organisation, you're sure to get some rumour-mongering. I'll put it to bed when I get back." Hank Laan, whose initial six weeks of sick leave have already expired, said he had notified the authority that he intends to return on January 15.

When we rang the authority his secretary said: "We don't have a time for his return." Ron Hicks, speaking for Laurie Brereton, said: "He is still on sick leave. We do not have a date for his return. We will have to make a decision in the near future about his position." □

ARCHITECTS WANTED: MUST HAVE MULTI-MILLION DOLLAR EXPERIENCE

By KEITH DUNSTAN

THE GREAT old Victorian State Library is in trouble. Its remarkable collection is deteriorating through lack of money, lack of staff and inadequate, outdated conditions.

However, there is hope in sight. After 15 years of talking by various governments the Cain Administration is honouring an electoral promise and is in the final stages of choosing an architect to produce a new \$80 million library on the site of the Queen Victoria Medical Centre. But will Melbourne get the library it wants?

Earlier this month the History Institute of Victoria held a public forum and some agonies became all too clear. Professor John Legge, chairman of the State Library Building committee explained what would happen. The whole site is huge, two city blocks bounded by Lonsdale, Latrobe, Russell and Swanston streets. It is split in half by Little Lonsdale Street.

The great old building which now houses the library and the State museum will be given entirely to the museum, except for the reading room. The reading room, although outdated for stacking books and a fire hazard, is one of the city's treasures. Of cathedral proportions, it was designed after the British Museum and the Library of Congress. This will remain as part of the new library and be connected to the main building by a flyover across Little Lonsdale Street.

The new library will go on the Queen Victoria site and the museum will get a portion of that site also.

But there are even more constraints on the architects. Three wings of the Queen Victoria face on to Lonsdale. They date

from the 1870s when it was the original Royal Melbourne Hospital. They must be saved.

Professor Legge explained that the committee had decided on a limited competition among eight leading firms and the Public Works Department. The firms are: Corrigan & McConnell Smith & Johnston and Clive Lucas; Greenhatch and Mitchell Giurgola & Thorp; Daryl Jackson Pty Ltd; Graeme Gunn and Perrott Lyon & Mathieson; Cameron Chisholm & Nichol; Philip Cox and Hayball & Sanderson; Ancher Mortlock & Woolley Pty Ltd; Denton Corker Marshall. All have been invited to submit preliminary plans.

There has been plenty of grief about that. The October edition of *Architect*, published by the Victorian chapter of the Royal Institute of Architects, read:

"The Victorian chapter welcomed the announcement of a competition but was appalled that 'firms applying for registration will be requested to demonstrate skill and experience in the design and construction of public buildings in excess of \$5 million.'

"That requirement precluded many new graduates and young, small firms from proving their skill. If such a clause had been in the 1953 competition for the Melbourne Olympic Swimming Pool, Borland, McIntyre and John and Phyllis Murphy could not have won..."

Architect mentioned that there were many surprises in the choice of the firms with some extraordinary exclusions including such firms as Peter McIntyre; Bates, Smart and McCutcheon and MHH Partnership.

Architect had also suggested that there was no brief for the new library.

Professor Legge denied at the meeting that there was no brief and that at this



Michael Rayner
The Queen Victoria Medical Centre

stage of the competition architects were not required to submit final plans.

But there was another angle. Val Austin, a Royal Melbourne Institute of Technology architecture student has used the State Library for her final thesis. She made a passionate plea for the old building. For months she has conducted an almost one-woman campaign. She says it is crazy to divorce the great old reading room from the main library and leave it in the middle of a museum.

She believes the entire library-museum building should be given over to the library. She says this way it will get more space and the modern technology the library seeks so desperately could be used to revitalise the old building.

Her plea was that the competing architects should at least be allowed to consider this option. As it was they had to put up with the tortuous problem of mixing new buildings with old.

Some time in the early 1990s, we will see a glorious library on the Queen Victoria site. The episode of how it all came about will make a marvellous book. □